2004 Hyundai Sonata LX

$2,500 · 143,000 miles · Private seller · Ridgecrest, CA

Seller: Private seller

Source: Facebook Marketplace

Listing: https://www.facebook.com/marketplace/item/1724944808597038/

Report generated October 30, 2026 · Ridgecrest Car Finder



Out-the-door price	Monthly cost to own	Reliability
$2,902	**$451**	**Average**
Set a budget in the Cost Calculator tab to compare.	loan + insurance + fuel + repairs + registration	3/5 · 1 recalls · 202 NHTSA complaints

Budget — buying it

Vehicle price	$2,500.00
Use tax (9.25%) — paid at DMV	$231.25
Vehicle license fee (0.65% of price)	$16.25
Registration + CHP fee	$108.00
Transportation improvement fee	$32.00
Title transfer	$15.00
Total out-the-door	$2,902.50
+ Pre-purchase inspection (you pay the shop)	$150.00

California taxes the full price — a trade-in does not reduce sales tax. DMV fees are estimates; the CA DMV fee calculator gives exact amounts.

Budget — paying for it

Down payment	$2,902.50
Amount financed	$0.00
Cash needed up front (down payment + inspection)	$3,052.50

Paid in full with your down payment — no loan needed.

Budget — owning it each month

Loan payment	$0.00
Insurance (estimate, liability)	$70.00
Fuel (1,000 mi/mo @ 20 MPG, $4.75/gal)	$237.50
Maintenance & repair reserve	$130.00
Registration renewal (÷12)	$13.85
Total per month	$451.35

Running costs without the loan: **$451/mo**. Estimated first-year cost of ownership: **$8,469** (out-the-door + inspection + 12 months of running costs + loan interest).

The repair reserve is set from the reliability rating and mileage: money to set aside, not a forecast.

Insurance

Coverage	Typical Ridgecrest range	Estimate used
Liability only (CA minimum 30/60/15)	$49–$112/mo	$70/mo
Full coverage (liability + collision + comprehensive)	$94–$243/mo	$135/mo

The budget above uses the **liability coverage** estimate ($70/mo). Get real quotes and enter one in the app to replace it.

• Vehicle class: typical car. Estimates assume an adult driver with a clean record; age, record, credit, and coverage limits change the price a lot.

• Ridgecrest is one of the cheapest places in California to insure a car (about $107–110/mo average).

• A lender will require full coverage. On an older, cheap car paid in cash, liability-only can make sense — but you'd pay for your own repairs after an at-fault accident.

• California's minimum (30/60/15) is low; $100k/$300k/$100k liability is commonly recommended.

• Ask about military/government discounts (NAWS China Lake), bundling, and low-mileage discounts.

Reliability

Rating: Average (3/5)

Average. The 2004 Sonata is a simple, cheap-to-fix car, but at 143k with a V6 (17 city MPG) it's a short-term option. 202 NHTSA complaints, mostly suspension and body structure.

NHTSA data for this model year: 1 recalls · 202 owner complaints (22 involving a crash). Most complaints: Suspension (56), Structure (47), Air Bags (46), Electrical System (17), Service Brakes (16), Steering (13).

Known issues for this model

• Timing belt must be replaced on schedule (~60k miles) - a snapped belt strands you

• Front lower control arm / subframe corrosion recall (09V-124)

• Crank or cam position sensor failures (stalling)

• Passenger airbag occupant-sensor faults

Check on this car before buying

• Ask for timing belt replacement records

- Run VIN: was the suspension recall done?
- Check for a lit airbag warning light
- Seller must provide a smog certificate

Notes

$2,500 (was $3,500), 143k mi, automatic, white/tan, likely the 2.7L V6 (listing shows 17 city MPG). 1 owner, clean title. Seller: no issues, runs perfectly, brand new tires; some seat damage and front bumper paint damage.

Cheapest clean-title car in town - a short-term 'bridge car' option.

2026-10-23: LISTING REMOVED - no longer on Facebook Marketplace (likely sold).

Vetting checklist (0/12 done)

- [ ] Checked KBB/Edmunds fair price
- [ ] Recalls checked / completed
- [ ] Clean title in seller's name
- [ ] Test drive incl. highway & hills
- [ ] No overheating; coolant clean
- [ ] Pre-purchase inspection
- [ ] VIN decoded & matches listing
- [ ] History report (Carfax/AutoCheck/NMVTIS)
- [ ] Valid smog cert (< 90 days)
- [ ] A/C cold after 15+ min
- [ ] Tires OK (tread, dry-rot, DOT date)
- [ ] Written out-the-door price

All costs and insurance figures are estimates for planning, not quotes. Confirm fees with the CA DMV, rates with insurers, and the car's condition with an independent pre-purchase inspection.